Introduction



JAWAHARLAL NEHRU HAS loomed like a colossus[1] over modern India – his life and legacy intimately intertwined with both its history and its present. As one of the leading lights of the nationalist movement, as one of the principal actors in the drama of Independence and Partition[2] and as India's first Prime Minister – Nehru fashioned the destiny of an entire subcontinent and left an indelible stamp on the history of South Asia. In the words of one biographer, he truly was 'among the tallest figures of the twentieth century'.[3] From his election as interim Prime Minister in 1946 to his end in 1964, and especially after the death of his deputy, Sardar Patel, in 1950, Nehru – as a contemporary observer recorded – 'wielded an authority usually reserved to dictators'.[4] In these 'unassailable years',[5] a pax-Nehruana, so to speak, when he was referred to as India's 'thaumaturgic personality',[6] his ideas moulded the imagination of two entire generations, defining the political contours of India and leaving an imprint so deep that they continue to be debated furiously by academics, intellectuals, commentators, journalists and politicians alike. 'The story of Jawaharlal Nehru,' as his obituary in the *New York Times* noted, 'is the story of contemporary India, which he in large part has shaped.'[7]

Nearly six decades after his passing, Nehru continues to make the newspapers with surprising regularity, not only in the context of the past but also in the context of the present. Deified and vilified in equal measure, he retains his centrality to political discourse, often cast as a player in current-day debates. In May 2021, for example, as India reeled from a ferocious second wave of Covid-19, furious commentators invoked Nehru to fulminate against the government's response. 'How Jawaharlal Nehru would have dealt with the Covid-19 pandemic in India,' ran one scathing headline in the newspaper *Gulf News*.[8] Writing soon after Nehru's death, the Australian diplomat (and Nehru biographer) Walter Crocker observed: